
1710–1778, BRITISH

Although he wrote music of various types (including Masses—he was a Catholic), Arne specialized in work for the stage (his sister was an actress and his wife a singer). He had long associations with two major London theaters (Covent Garden and Drury Lane) and also with Vauxhall Gardens, a leading center of popular entertainment. His large output includes operas, oratorios, masques, and incidental music for plays. Much of his work is routine, but at his best he had a memorable gift for melody, as in his most famous piece, the stirring song “Rule, Britannia!” It was originally part of Arne’s patriotic masque *Alfred* (about Alfred the Great), but it was such a success that it quickly achieved an independent life. His other famous songs include “Where the Bee Sucks,” sung by Ariel in Shakespeare’s *The Tempest*.

KEY WORKS: *Comus*, 1738; *Alfred*, 1740; *Music for The Tempest*, 1740, *Artaxerxes*, 1762; *Love in a Village*, 1762